

What is research problem?

- Activity @ <http://padlet.com/razifshahril/HFS4343Topic4>



What is research problem?

- Any question that you want answered and any assumption or assertion that you want to challenge or investigate.
- *However;*
 - not all questions can be transformed into research problems.
 - the process of formulating them in a meaningful way is not at all an easy task.
 - it requires considerable knowledge of both the subject area and research methodology.

What is research problem? (cont.)

- A research problem is a perceived gap between what is and what should be.
- Research problem arise from;
 - Evolution of theories.
 - Peers and supervisors etc.
 - Published research (literature review).
 - Day-to-day experience



where

do we go

from

here?

**Research
problem is like
an identification
of destination
before
undertaking
research journey**

**Clear research problem would
result in clear and economical
research plan.**



RESEARCH PROBLEM IS THE FOUNDATION OF THE RESEARCH STUDY

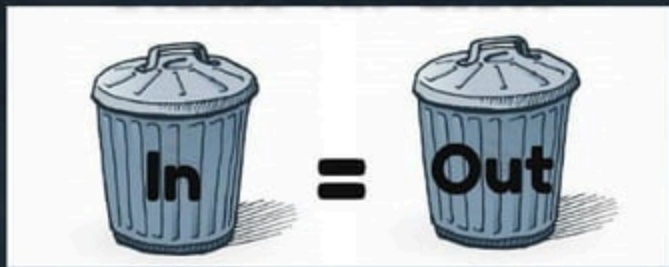


WHAT IT IS THAT YOU **WANT TO FIND**
OUT ABOUT AND NOT WHAT YOU
THINK YOU MUST FIND

The way we formulate the research problem determines every step that follows;

- type of study design that can be used
- type of sampling strategy that can be employed
- research instrument that can be used or developed
- type of analysis that can be undertaken



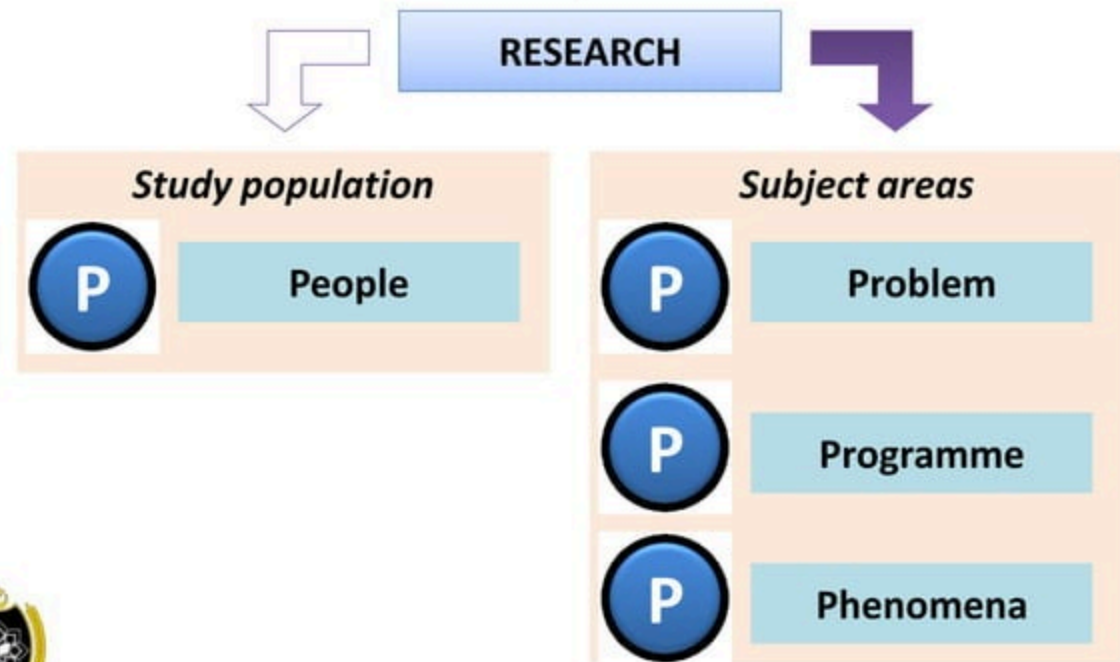


**GARBAGE IN,
GARBAGE OUT.**

Sources of research problems



Sources of research problem (cont.)



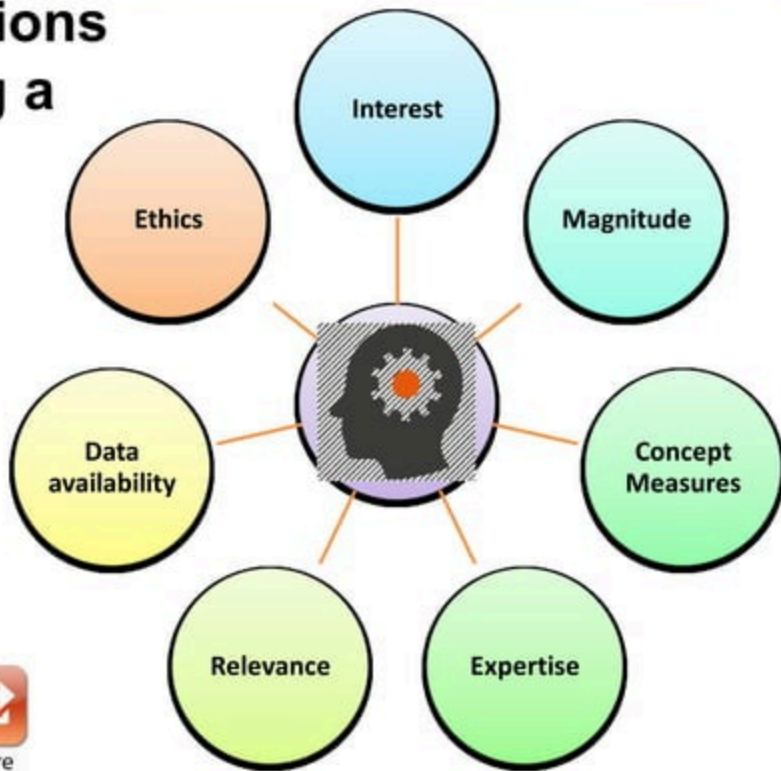
Aspects of research problem

Aspects of study	About	Study of	
Study population	People	Individuals, organizations, groups, communities	They provide you with the required information or you collect information from or about them
Subject area	Problem	Issues, situations, associations, needs, population composition, profiles etc.	Information that you need to collect to find answers to your service research questions
	Programme	Contents, structure, outcomes, attributes, satisfaction, consumers, providers etc	
	Phenomenon	Cause and effect, relationships, the study of a phenomenon itself etc	

Identifying research problem

- Differentiate between research vs. non-research problems.
- Non-research problems are answered by these questions:
 - *Can it be solved by administrative changes?*
 - *Are there already solutions available that can be used?*
 - *Is the problem due to lack of manpower and resources?*
 - *Is there data showing that it is not a significant issue?*

Considerations in selecting a research problem



Prioritizing research problem

1 Relevance

- How important?
- Size, severity, health & social consequences?

2 Duplication

- Is the answer already available from other studies?

3 Feasibility

- Feasible to carry out remedial actions?
- Are the manpower, time and resources available?

4 Applicability

- Potential solution is effective under ideal conditions?
- Will managers accept and use it?

Prioritizing research problem (cont.)

5 Cost effectiveness

- Are the resources invested worth the outcome?
- Will the solution be too expensive to implement?

6 Timeliness

- Will the answer come quick enough?

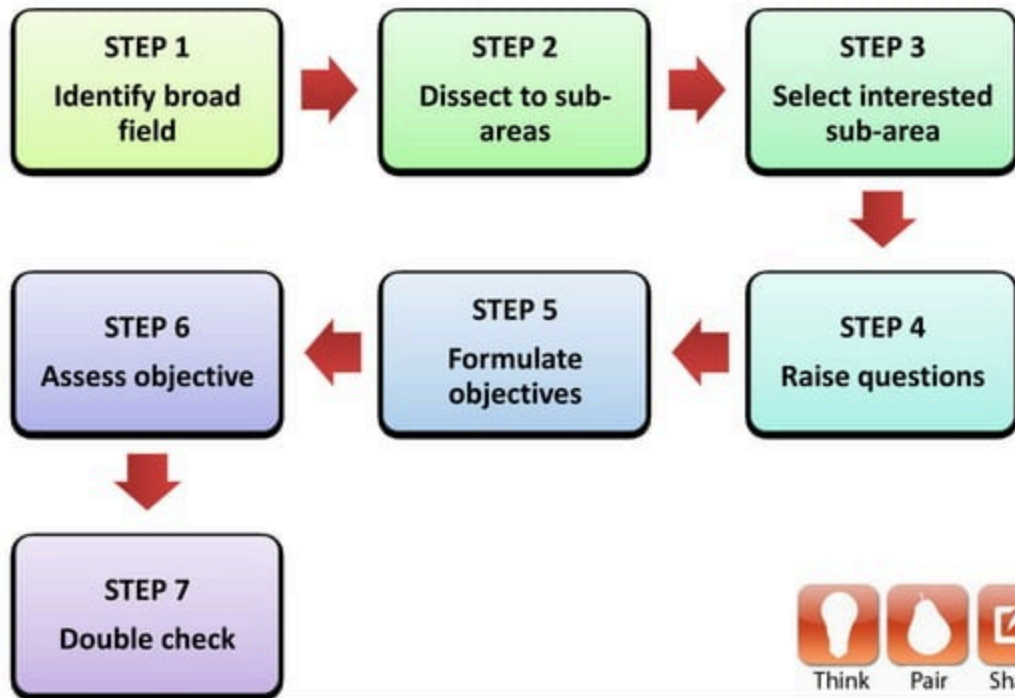
7 Ethics

- Will the project be acceptable to the respondents?

8 Political acceptability

- Will the managers and community accept the results?

Steps in formulating research problem



Formulation of research objectives

- What is an 'objective'?
 - A clear and specific goals you set out to attain in your study.
- Two types of objectives;
 - Main objectives
 - Specific objectives / sub-objectives

MAIN OBJECTIVES

- Overall statement of the thrust of your study.
- It is also a statement of the main associations and relationships that you seek to discover or establish

SUB-OBJECTIVES

- The specific aspects of the topic that you want to investigate within the main framework of your study
- One sub-objective contains one aspect only

Formulation of research objectives (cont.)

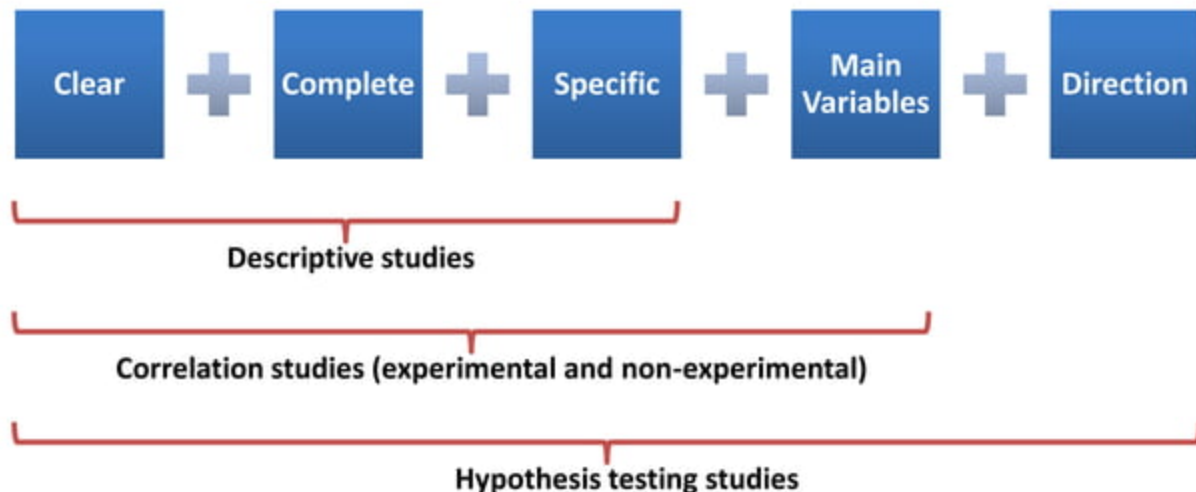
- Sub-objectives should be numerically listed.
- Worded clearly and unambiguously.
- Use **action-oriented words** or verbs when writing your objectives.
- E.g. start with;
 - ‘to determine’, ‘to find out’, ‘to ascertain’, ‘to measure’ and ‘to explore’
- the wording of your objectives determines the type of research design you need to adopt to achieve them.

Functions of research objectives

- **Focus** the study (narrowing it down to essentials).
- **Avoid** the collection of data which are not strictly necessary for understanding and solving the problem you have identified.
- **Organize** the study in clearly defined parts or phases.



Characteristics of objectives



Establishing operational definition

- **Working definitions or operational definitions** are pre-defined concepts that you plan to use either in your research problem and/or in identifying the study population in a measurable form.
- Used only for the purpose of your study and could be quite different to legal definitions, or those used by others.
- Working definitions will inform your readers what exactly you mean by the concepts that you have used in your study to avoid ambiguity and confusion.